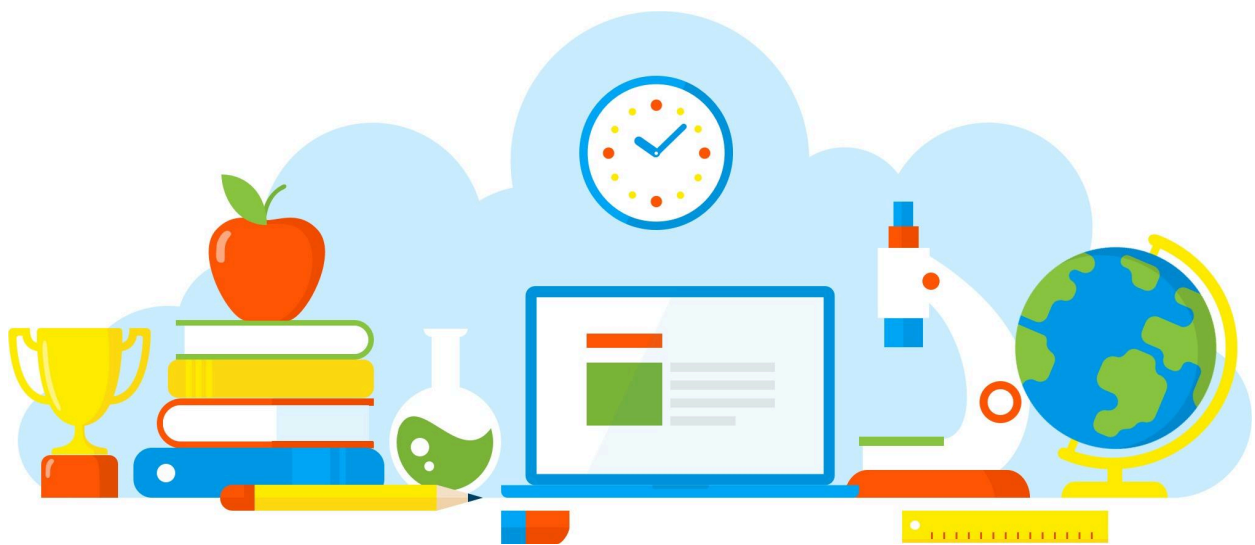




Career Opportunities for Spouses

A guide to help you manage your passport and visa paperwork and understand your employment options in the UK..

Moving overseas as a military spouse is an incredible adventure, but it also requires navigating some unique administrative hurdles. From ensuring you have the right stamp in your passport to finding a rewarding career—either on-base or in the local British community—having a clear roadmap is key to a smooth transition.

Below is a comprehensive guide to help you manage your passport and visa paperwork and understand your employment options in the UK.

Part 1: Passport & Visa Requirements (The Legal Essentials)

Before you pack your bags, you must ensure your travel documents are fully processed. Entering the UK on the wrong passport status can lead to severe delays or even deportation at the border.

1. The US No-Fee Passport (Your Official Entry)

All command-sponsored military dependents who are US citizens are required to have an official **US No-Fee Passport**.

- **Requirements:** You must be officially named on your sponsor's PCS orders to obtain this passport.

- **Usage:** This passport is strictly for official travel (e.g., PCSing to and from the UK) and serves as your legal residency document while living in the UK.
- *Note:* If you are a non-US citizen dependent, you will need to utilize your foreign tourist passport and contact the base passport office early to secure the correct entry clearance.

2. The Blue Tourist Passport (For Leisure Travel)

Do not rely solely on your No-Fee Passport. Command-sponsored spouses are highly encouraged to have a standard **regular Blue Tourist Passport** before departing the US.

- **Why you need it:** You cannot use a No-Fee Passport for leisure travel, vacations, or weekend hops to mainland Europe.
- If you cannot get one before leaving CONUS, you can apply for one at the RAF Lakenheath or RAF Mildenhall Passport Offices once you arrive.

3. The Exemption Vignette (Your "Visa")

US military members do not require a visa to reside in the UK, but their dependents do. Instead of a traditional visa, command-sponsored spouses must obtain an **Exemption Vignette**.

- **What it is:** A physical foil sticker placed in your No-Fee Passport by the UK government. It proves to British border officials, landlords, schools, and local employers that you are exempt from UK immigration control for the duration of your sponsor's tour.
- **How to get it:** You can apply for this stamp through the RAF Lakenheath or RAF Mildenhall Passport Offices. The process can take between **8 to 10 weeks**, so apply as early as possible.

Part 2: Employment & Careers in the UK

Finding work overseas can be challenging, but there are plenty of avenues available—ranging from US civil service careers on-base to local jobs in historic British towns.

1. On-Base Employment Opportunities

Working on-base is the most popular choice for spouses because it keeps you within the US federal employment system and avoids complex UK tax filings.

- **Federal Civil Service (GS Jobs):** High-paying professional, administrative, and clinical roles on-base. These are applied for via [USAJobs](#).
 - *Preference:* You can utilize **Military Spouse Preference (MSP)** to gain priority in the hiring process starting up to 30 days before your arrival.

- **Non-Appropriated Funds (NAF):** Managed by the **48th Forces Support Squadron (FSS)**. These jobs include roles in base recreation, youth centers, administrative assistance, and lodging.
- **AAFES (Exchange) & DeCA (Commissary):** Great entry-level retail and customer service roles at the Base Exchange, Shoppettes, base fast-food vendors, or the commissary.
- **DoD Education Activity (DoDEA):** Full-time teaching positions, substitute roles, administrative staff, and educational aides at the base schools.
- **Private Defense Contractors:** Major companies like Northrop Grumman and Sterling Medical operate at Lakenheath and hire administrative, technological, and medical personnel.

ALL OPPORTUNITIES AVAILABLE IN THE TRIBASE AREA CAN BE LOCATED HERE:

https://padlet.com/48fsssfshvolunteer/tri-base-employment-board-77bpjqkkcdza60nd?contribution_type=draftPost

2. Off-Base Employment (The British Economy)

Under the NATO Status of Forces Agreement (SOFA), command-sponsored spouses with an **Exemption Vignette** (and no work restrictions in their passport) are legally entitled to work on the local British economy without needing a UK work permit.

- **Finding a Job:** You can search local UK vacancies using the government's [Find a Job Service](#) or visit local Jobcentre Plus offices. Nearby Bury St Edmunds and Ely offer retail, hospitality, and education roles, while Cambridge (45 minutes away) offers high-paying clinical, tech, and professional positions.
- **National Insurance Number (NIN):** Before you can begin working off-base or register as self-employed, you must apply for a NIN (the UK equivalent of a Social Security Number). You can request this by contacting Jobcentre Plus.
- **British Income Tax:** Keep in mind that while active-duty military pay is protected under the SOFA, **spousal income earned off-base is subject to British Income Tax**. This tax is typically withheld directly from your paycheck (via Pay As You Earn - PAYE).

3. Remote Work and Home-Based Businesses (HBB)

- **Remote Work for US Companies:** If you plan to keep your current US remote job while living in the UK, be cautious. The NATO SOFA does *not* provide tax or legal protections for international remote work. Your US employer must be willing to navigate UK employment laws, and your income will likely be subject to UK taxes and National Insurance.

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- **Home-Based Businesses (HBB):** If you want to run a business from your on-base military quarters (like photography, baking, or consulting), you must obtain formal approval from the Garrison Commander or Senior Commander before operating.
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Part 3: Support Resources & Job Hunting Prep

As you prepare for the move, make sure to take advantage of the support systems designed to help you succeed:

- **Military & Family Readiness Center (MFRC):** Located at RAF Lakenheath, the MFRC is your primary resource for spouse employment. They offer resume review workshops (converting your US resume to a UK-friendly CV), mock interviews, and have a dedicated UK Employment Guide. You can book appointments directly via [Lakenheath FSS](#).
- **Spouse Employment Program:** The MFRC also offers active-duty Air Force and Space Force spouses up to \$2,500 in funding for short-term certifications or job training programs (3–12 weeks) that lead to immediate employment.